

and maintaining the Internet. If it's marketing, then it's a good bet that the majority of the company's online efforts will be devoted to marketing. Weblogs give every department, and every individual in every department, the ability to leverage the Web according to his or her needs. Plus there's a certain element of personal power that's hard to deny. Suddenly the best thinkers have their own digital voice that they manage and control themselves.

To that end, weblogs are proving that proactive employees are hungry to try something new. Especially if it can dramatically enhance their effectiveness. Salespeople are creating tight, weblog-based communities with like-minded customers. R&D specialists are building weblog communities with colleagues within the company and with industry peers at large. One book retailer uses a weblog as a less expensive and more effective way to host an author appearance. The author is given a web address to a branded template that is ready and waiting for content. A few sentences gets the discussion thread going and within minutes readers are reviewing characters, discussing plot lines, asking questions and sharing perspectives with others interested in the same book.

From Knowledge Management to Sales

One of the most significant outcomes of all is how weblogs are changing the process of Knowledge Management. Weblogs can archive themselves and eliminate the need for a cumbersome e-library. They can be searched by publisher or by topic. More importantly, they are turning knowledge management from a lump of information that resides on a distant server into a real-time, dynamic exchange among certain groups. Example: A large packaged goods company can have a weblog, published by the senior product manager, for every product - a perpetually "live" communication destination for sales, marketing, and R&D teams. Every morning, the product managers post updates right from their desktops (they can even do it while they're on the road). The rest of the product's weblog community can then check in and review sales numbers, post manufacturing issues, suggest improvements, review upcoming marketing rollouts, and check inventory ther-